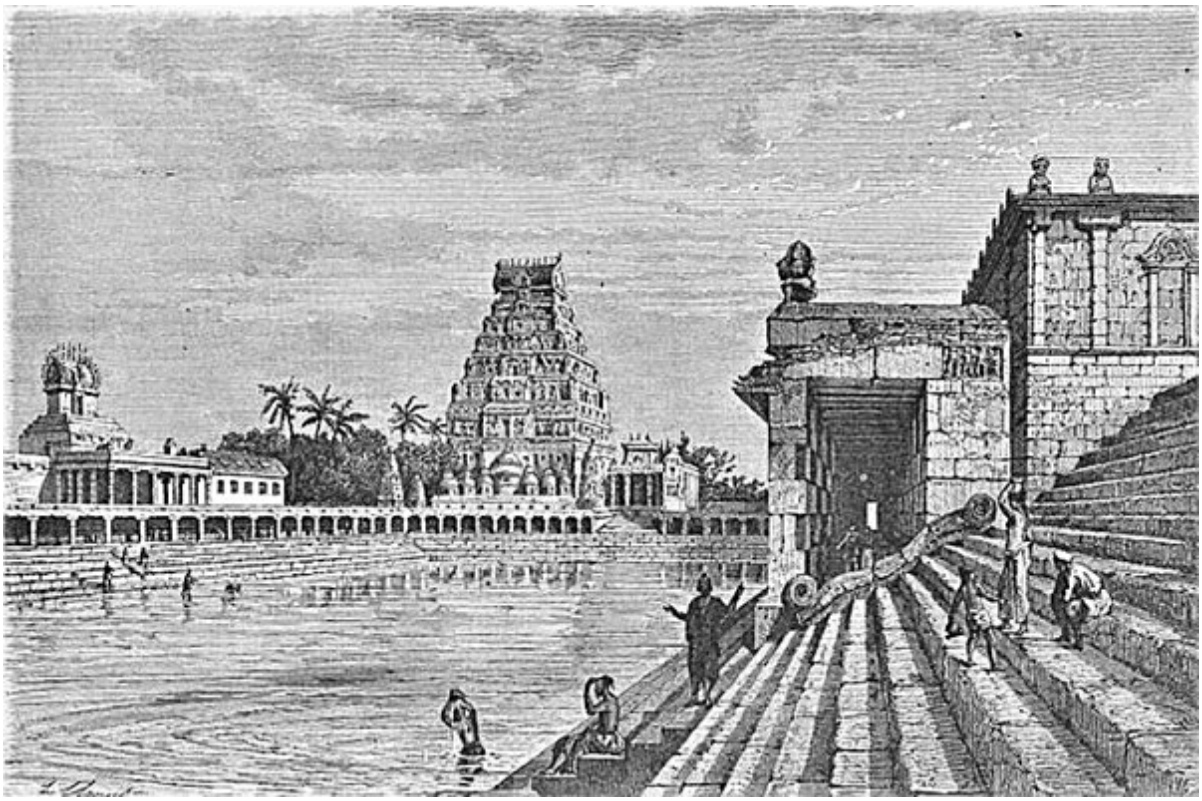
way, the linga is the prime image of Shaivism. But here at Chidambaram the presiding deity is Lord Shiva in anthropomorphic form, transformed through the malleable medium of copper alloy into a vibrant, free-standing male dancer. He is Kuttuperumal, the ‘Lord of the Dance’, or Adavallan, ‘Master of the Dance’, both derived from the same Tamil source: *Koothu*, dance (noun) and *aadu*, to dance (verb). In this form he is a manifestation of Shiva better known outside Tamil Nadu and Kerala in its Sanskrit form as *Nataraja*.



The great tank of the Nataraja temple of Chidambaram, a supreme example of Chola art and architecture spread over many centuries, as engraved by an unknown artist in the 1870s.

Today we take Shiva Nataraja, the cosmic dancer, for granted, because we have seen him so often in books, brochures and posters. But imagine how overwhelming, if not downright shocking, this new manifestation of Lord